THE POST-2011 PEACE PROJECT

Background

After taking office in March 2011, President Thein Sein sought to break from the former military government by resolving the country's biggest challenge, the decades-long fight between the government and the EAGs. The ethnic policy under President Thein Sein was historically unprecedented in ideological, strategic, and operational terms. Ideologically, unlike ceasefire truces under previous military governments, which did not seek political dialogue with EAGs, a "federal union" became the vision of the new ethnic policy (Tun Tun Thein 2014). Strategically, the government now held peace talks of a collective nature that accepted ethnic political alliance groups as dialogue partners when the ceasefire talks reached the union level. This was contradictory to the previous military regime's ceasefire arrangements, where deals were made with individual EAGs. Lastly and importantly, the new operational style for policy implementation was clearly unorthodox. The new government relied on a resourceful technical institution made up of civilian experts to implement its peace policy agenda, whereas previously the military was solely in charge of ceasefire arrangements. This peace technical team served as the main political outreach of President Thein Sein to implement his policy initiatives on the ethnic conflict.

Resumption of conflict in north and northeast Myanmar became a major disadvantage for the new government. The president framed and identified the issue of armed clashes as a problem for "national unity" in light of the political transition towards democratization. Therefore, the government sought to move beyond mere ceasefire arrangements with the EAGs. The government officially aimed to bring all the EAGs into mainstream politics through political dialogue. On 18 August 2011, President Thein Sein announced his official invitation to all ethnic groups to peace talks by dropping the demand that they first convert to the Border Guard Force (BGF).[2] He offered two-tier peace talks — initially, to implement a preliminary peace program with state/regional-level governments, and then hold union-level peace discussions with the union government's peace team (New Light Of Myanmar 2011).[3] This was the first official nationwide announcement to all ethnic groups in decades.[4] It